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COMMENTARY



Ranting, raving and complaining: reflections on working against orthodoxy

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My dear colleague Professor Fenwick W. English often reminds me that you make more friends with honey than vinegar. I would like to say that he has only needed to remind of this on one occasion, but that would be a lie. And in this piece, I am once again going to let him down. In this article, I draw on previous work I have undertaken on social epistemology in educational administration and leadership (e.g. Eacott, 2017b) and bring that into conversation with a recent publication of mine that was met with mixed reviews (Eacott, 2017a). In doing so, I argue that educational administration and leadership, and arguably education research at large, is not well equipped for dealing with dialogue and debate. Instead, what we are more likely to experience, both as consumers and generators of research is ‘parallel monologues’. Even when debating one another, as many potentially seek in journals and at conferences, there is often little if any serious attempt to engage with the ideas of others as this becomes secondary to enforcing one’s opinion on the other.

Attempting to move beyond parallel monologues has become somewhat of a focus of mine. Works such as an edited Special Issue of the *Journal of Educational Administration and Foundations* (Vol. 26 No. 2) and, more recently, *Beyond Leadership: A Relational Approach to Organizational Theory in Education* (Eacott, 2018) have sought to demonstrate the normative position that I hold, following Pierre Bourdieu and others, on the logic of scholarship – argument and refutation.

For the most part, doctoral programs in educational administration and leadership do not prepare candidates for dialogue and debate. Neither do conferences and/or scholarly journals. Long gone are the back and forth exchanges in the pages of the field’s journals such as those seen between Willower (1983), Hills (1982, 1983), Gronn (1982, 1987) and Thomas (1986) regarding the usefulness of observational studies or the programmatic articulation, critique and defense demonstrated in Colin Evers and Gabriele Lakomski’s (1991, 1996, 2000) trilogy, *Knowing, Exploring and Doing Educational Administration*.¹

While I am aware of Bush’s (2017) rebuttal (not refutation) of my claim of parallel monologues, I am more persuaded by the insights of Robert Donmoyer (2001), Martin Thrupp and Richard Willmott (2003), and Jill Blackmore (2010), that in educational administration and leadership we treat those with whom we disagree with benign neglect and apathy more than intellectual engagement. For the most part, one finds their community or network of like-minded scholars with accompanying journals, conferences and the like and carves out a career – often blissfully unaware of scholarly dialogue and

debate taking place within and beyond their chosen fields/sub-fields. There are salutatory acknowledgments to the need for multi-disciplinary and inter-disciplinary approaches but arguably the traces of the paradigm wars have meant even some of the most senior professors in the field struggle to meaningfully engage with those writing from different positions – something that can be evidenced in the commentary chapters in the recent collection *Questioning Leadership* (Lakomski, Eacott, & Evers, 2017) and to some extent, *Beyond Leadership* (Eacott, 2018).

As noted earlier, in this commentary piece I am going to use an example of paper I had published in 2017 to make some claims about the quality of dialogue and debate in educational administration and leadership. While only an *n* of one, and therefore going to be dismissed by some of those imposing different criteria for the justification of knowledge claims, I argue that my experience is symbolic of the logic of educational administration and leadership as a scholarly field – one where it is rare to explicitly engage, not just randomly cite to demonstrate awareness, but actually engage with the knowledge claims of those outside your immediate scholarly location. To that end, it is not a commentary on the boundaries of the discipline (e.g. Oplatka, 2009) or the various traditions within educational administration and leadership (e.g. Gunter, 2016), as these matters have been taken up, and much better than I could, by other scholars. Instead, this is a comment about the social epistemology of the field, and the ways in which dialogue and debate is generated through the logic of academic work.

The case

In the first half of 2017, I had a paper published in *School Leadership and Management* entitled ‘School leadership and the cult of the guru: The neo-Taylorism of Hattie’ (Eacott, 2017a). There are two subtle moves in the title that would only be observed by those familiar with the history of the field and dare I say lost on many of its critics. First, the initial part of the title is an explicit acknowledgment to Callahan’s (1962) classic *Education and the cult of efficiency*. For those unfamiliar with this text – and if so, go and read it – it offers an account of how during the first half of the twentieth century, public school reforms in the U.S.A. were more influenced by management practices, and in particular Taylorism, than educational. This argument remains as relevant to contemporary Australia as it was the U.S.A. at its time of printing. Second, the notion of ‘Neo-Taylorism’, that which itself has ties to Callahan, and obviously Taylor’s (1911) *The principles of scientific management*, is an acknowledgment to the work of Peter Gronn (incidentally in dialogue with Ross Thomas), and Hodgkinson (1978). In raising their arguments, both Gronn and Hodgkinson were discussing epistemology and its implications for methodology in educational administration and leadership – basically what it means to know something (and in the case of Gronn, there is a useful link to the work of Geertz (1973) (more people should read about the ‘Balinese cock fight’) and more specifically Ryle (1971) on ‘the wink’. In dialoguing with Thomas, Gronn makes reference to ‘thick description’ through Geertz. Demonstrating a lack of awareness of Geertz, Thomas dismisses such claims as mere semantics and it was in reading this exchange that my attention to the nature of dialogue and debate in educational administration and leadership became of considerable interest. As not only is it rare to see academics engaging with one another but when they do, it is often on uncommon terrain.

Against this backdrop, I seek to build my argument on three key markers: (i) the logic of engagement (both positive and negative) to my paper; (ii) the treatment by the Editor of *School Leadership & Management*; and (iii) what this demonstrates about scholarly dialogue and debate in educational administration and leadership.

Dissemination and its challenges

As with many journals in the contemporary age, following acceptance of the paper (after two rounds of review and a delay during a changeover of editorial teams) and copyediting, the paper was made available as a 'Latest paper' (OnlineFirst, Earlycite, depending on your publisher) with the usual template email making me aware and asking me to help promote the paper courtesy of 50 free copies. For those of you who know me well, I am never afraid of a little shameless self-promotion (and I have completed the training, see Hugh Kearns and Maria Gardner's ithinkwell.com.au), and therefore shared the promotional text via multiple social media platforms (e.g. Twitter, Facebook) after a careful strategic approach to marketing where I had been flagging the paper as forthcoming for a few months.

The release of the paper was met with a flurry of activity. Within the first 24 h I received emails from colleagues in the academy across Australia, New Zealand, Canada, Bahrain, Scotland and Denmark, among others. Similarly, through Twitter I had public and private messages from a number of followers, and even picked up a few new followers. This is the closest I have ever been to generating something that has gone viral. Publication of the paper has led to speaking engagements with professional associations at regional and state levels. In short, it has been a successful dissemination process and at time of submitting this article, it has been downloaded over 1000 times on the official journal website and many other times via my personal website and email requests to me. To this day I continue to get emails, increasingly coming from school-based educators with narratives of the **Cult of Guru and its implications for their work**.

The reactions to the paper have, however, been mixed. And consistent with many others academics, despite the positive interactions far out numbering the negative, it is the latter that I dwell on and trouble me.

While being the basis of a few blogs,² one particular commentator – an early-stage doctoral candidate – took particular aim at my work, labeling it a mere 'opinion piece' and a work of fiction rather than research. He opted to write on his personal blog, and again on LinkedIn, and promote it via Twitter. All of which without making me aware of it, I just happened to randomly come across it. Something that in itself is interesting for the way those in the field engage with one another. A willingness to attack someone's research but not make them aware. I do, however, note he did engage with me over a weekend (3 days) via Twitter, albeit constantly dismissing my work. At the heart of this individual's critique of my paper was what he saw as a dismissal of evidence-based practice and my lack of empirical work to support my case. The justification of what counts as empirical work is contested, and I would argue – and more than willing to defend – that the examples I provided were empirical examples of the Cult of Hattie even if I did not 'collect' data or speak to people.

Similarly taking offence at my paper, but rather than blogging choosing to complain to the Deputy Vice Chancellor – Research of my university, another individual did not like what he saw as an attack on Professor John Hattie and the idea of evidence-based strategies.

While I can accept that my communication skills (or lack thereof) may have contributed to the mis-recognition of my argument, my claims were not against evidence-based approaches to teaching but instead against the uncritical acceptance of a single master narrative of what that looks like. The paper makes an argument about the *spatio-temporal conditions* which made it possible for Hattie's work to reach such a level of acceptance and legitimation and the various *auctors* (s/he who generates) that have contributed to generating these conditions. This is why I claim the paper is not an attack on John Hattie, but a critical commentary on Brand Hattie and what I label as the Cult of Hattie. This is not to negate Hattie's complicity in the expanding commercial interests he has acquired even though he declares his lack of business acumen in a recent piece by Knudsen (2017).

Fortunately for me, and after building a short case and supplying a copy of the paper for those investigating the matter at my university, it was considered a non-event and my paper was not considered controversial and deemed appropriate having been subjected to two rounds of peer review. That said, the journal and, in particular, the newly appointed Editor in Chief also interacted with the paper in an un-usual way – at least in my experience of publishing in academic journals.

Treatment of the paper

Following my initial tweet, which included the official (and newly launched) journal twitter account, the Editor responded (both publicly and privately). It was simply to highlight that my paper had not been published in the journal and was merely available online first and would appear in a forthcoming issue. There was nothing controversial (from myself or the editor) in the exchange and a professional interaction.

A few months later, just before the paper was assigned to an issue, late on a Saturday evening I received a random email from John Hattie (without a subject line I might add – so I did consider it may have been a fake email) stating he had written a response and would be able to share soon. The next evening he sent through a copy of his response with the offer to accept feedback and possibly to write together in the future. As a complicit neoliberal subject, my initial thoughts were the potential spike in citations I might get in co-authoring with a Laureate Professor of Guru status, but my more substantive attention and primary concern was with the content of his response and how he engaged with my central thesis.

Disappointingly, Hattie's response was in my opinion, inadequate. Apart from being received and published within two days (as opposed to my many months and multiple rounds of review, but that would be evidence to confirm my claim of guru status legitimized by the editor wouldn't it), Hattie, much like the bloggers, mis-recognized my argument. Hattie (2017) suggests 'Eacott seems to deride rigour, robustness, and the "pursuit of effectiveness and efficiency" as these, he claims, were "central to Taylorism"' (p. 429). He goes on to argue:

The extreme claims that the work if uncritically accepted by professional organisations like ACEL [Australian Council for Educational Leaders] is easily countered with reference to their web page that lists many other speakers, papers, critics, and alternatives. I note it is Eacott, not ACEL nor educators or administrators across Australia that has tried 'to elevate that individual to guru status'. (Hattie, 2017, p. 429)

While Hattie is correct that there are other people named on the ACEL website, including those rolled out regularly as keynote speakers at educational leadership conferences (e.g. Michael Fullan, Andy Hargreaves, Pasi Sahlberg, Alma Harris, Yong Zhou), his engagement is different. Despite substantive critiques of his approach (e.g. Higgins & Simpson, 2011; Snook, Clark, Harker, O'Neill, & O'Neill, 2010; Snook, O'Neill, Clark, O'Neill, & Openshaw, 2009; Terhart, 2011), his work is cited by politicians and associations as though it is irrefutable fact (e.g. 12 months growth for 1 year at school) not to mention his role at key bodies such as the Australian Institute for Teaching and School Leadership (AITSL).

The genesis stimulus for the paper was having taught consecutive cohorts of students in my Master of Educational Leadership courses where participants identified as teaching at 'Hattie schools'. As part of unpacking the history of educational administration and leadership, specifically as it relates to effective schools, I articulated the claims that constituted the eventual paper. Hattie's work was already hegemonic in school systems, promoted by professional associations, and with substantial commercial arrangements (e.g. Corwin, partnerships between Corwin and ACEL,³ and systemic contracts to deliver school leadership preparation) prior to my paper. While others may not have used the label the 'Cult of Hattie', the discourse was already alive and well.

Demonstrating a lack of historical knowledge of the field, or simple engagement with my argument, Hattie goes on to state:

he [Eacott] argues that the cult of Hattie is a tragedy in Australian school leadership. It is hard to judge what this tragedy is – the hint is the 'uncritical adoption of any one position is problematic' and who would disagree with this but where is the evidence there is but one position? No fear, there are many critics, as there should be, to the ideas of VL. (Hattie, 2017, p. 429)

He goes on to re-articulate his position as one concerned with moving from 'what works' to 'what works best' (p. 430), once again demonstrating an absence of understanding Taylorism and his pursuit of 'one right method' and maximum efficiency. Hattie's work is Taylorism for a new time. To prevent what Taylor labeled as 'soldiering' and Hattie labels as 'coasting', schools need to focus attention on the practice – using a piecemeal reduction in tasks to their smallest components as Taylor did – and the execution of that practice with the greatest impact. Herein is the difference between Hattie's work and other reform work in Australia in the previous decades. While initiatives such as *Productive Pedagogies* and *Quality Teaching* sought to provide teachers and school leaders with resources to reflect on and develop their craft, Hattie's list of practices by effect size tells educators what to do to get maximum return. The difference is subtle, but important. Hattie seeks to tell teachers what to do on the basis of what is presented as robust scientific evidence (irrespective of its critiques and failure to systemically refute counter claims). To that end, the proliferation of brand Hattie throughout the Australian education system is akin to the spread of Taylorism across the U.S.A. school system in the early twentieth century and therefore consistent with Callahan's claim of a tragedy. This is not to deny the absence of critique, but the at-scale adoption of professional associations (e.g. through keynotes, on-selling of books/products and promotion of workshops), policymakers (e.g. mobilizing the language of 'Hattie says' or 'research from Hattie says'), and school systems (e.g. funding professional learning based on *Visible Learning*, and the identification of Hattie schools)

is evidence of a largely uncritical adoption of the work when no dissenters or counter arguments are included.

I sought to reply to Hattie's response, given what I saw as a mis-recognition of my argument, but was declined the opportunity by the Editor. She was polite, citing that 'we have many new authors waiting to publish in SLAM and many manuscripts in progress. So while we appreciate your offer, we need to respectfully decline'. While polite and justified, the decline does say something about the logic of academic work in educational administration and leadership and the priority given to dialogue and debate. Note my argument here is not explicitly against the Editor, rather a comment on the logic of academic work in the field. Even Hattie (2017) notes in his reply:

Our discipline needs to be saturated with critique of ideas; and it should be welcomed. Every paradigm or set of conjectures should be tested to destruction and its authors, adherents, and users of the ideas should face public accountability. Thesis-antithesis-synthesis is well built into the water of academia. This surely should be the norm. (p. 428)

In principle, I agree for the most part with what Hattie is claiming here. However, I would argue for the logic of academic work being argument-refutation and not thesis-antithesis-synthesis. The distinction is more than important, it is fundamental to the issue at hand. Hattie did produce an antithesis to my original paper. His response made a counter argument to my claims. To do so, he did not need to engage with my ideas on anything but a superficial level (to think with Ryle, this is the wink all over – a focus on a few words without grasping their underlying generative meaning). There was no refutation of my claims. There was no testing of my ideas to destruction and no public accountability for his analysis. If anything, he simply dismissed my ideas with minimal reference to any evidence. For example, given my argument for his work being Tayloristic (and supporting evidence), in what ways is his work beyond that of Taylor? Are there no commercial arrangements with ACEL? Is his work not highly influential in policy discussions despite questioning of the very foundations of his analysis? Is his name not deployed by politicians, systemic authorities and school leaders as an authority/authoritative source? If anything, what Hattie has inadvertently done is support my argument while attempting to refute it.

The logic of academic work

As I have argued elsewhere, educational administration and leadership as a field of inquiry is prone to parallel monologues. Even when engaging with one another, there is a major struggle to step outside our comfort zone and seriously engage with knowledge claims that do not confirm that which we hold dear. It is not about simply producing a counter argument, but engaging with the ideas of another and where necessary refuting them. Not imposing one's view of the world on another, but engage on their terms – testing out claims for robustness and internal coherence and not alignment with one's own normative position. This removes subjectivity in the dismissal of ideas and instead provides the basis for a more rigorous and robust exchange of ideas.

My claims against the Cult of the Guru, or more specifically the Cult of Hattie, were that unlike past work (e.g. Robinson, Lloyd, & Rowe, 2008), Hattie provided the work in the language of administrators. It was not broad areas with greatest impact but more specific practices that could generate the greatest return on investment.

The issue that I have is with the uncritical adherence to a single master narrative of improving schools. After all, a discussion of how best to improve schooling (as with research) is based on a normative position. One where the pre-existing orientation of the claimant explicitly shapes any judgment made. Work that confirms is fantastic, supported, promoted and cited. Work that disconfirms is given an alternate label and/or dismissed and considered as deficit.

For me, the logic of academic work is argument and refutation. To do so requires engaging with knowledge claims on common grounds and not dismissing. This is why I have chosen to have others engage with my work in special issues and my recent book. It is why I actively seek out dialogue and debate in what I read. All of this is my normative position on how scholarship ought to be conducted. Through far greater reflexivity at scale, I believe that the field to which I am most commonly aligned, educational administration and leadership would benefit not in building the careers of the next guru, but in advancing knowledge claims. To that end, despite this article potentially giving the impression that it was others doing the ranting, raving and complaining about my Cult of the Guru paper, it has really been an exercise in me building a case for how I believe we ought to conduct ourselves as scholars. To that end, over the coming years in journals, at conferences, in seminars and any scholarly event, I hope to see less ranting, raving, and complaining (myself included) and more serious engagement with the knowledge claims of those presenting. What I have not provided is a list of how to challenge the existing regime. Arguably, providing such a list would be contrary to what I have claimed in this article. Instead, what I have offered is a call or invitation to others to engage differently in our work. It is not a call for knowledge centrism and/or one way to be a scholar, but an in-principle agreement that our work as scholars be recognizable for its underlying generative logic of argument and refutation. This offers a path to overcoming the parallel monologues that constitute the publications (journals, books) and sustain the various sub-fields of educational administration and leadership by focusing on generating and advancing ideas.

Notes

1. I do note that EAQ has recently published a response (Romero & Mitchell, 2018).
2. For example, Deborah Netolicky (<https://theeduflaneuse.com/2017/05/26/edu-gurus/>) Jon Andrews <https://jonandrews.edublogs.org/2017/05/20/update-opportunity-knocks-again-and-again-and-again/>; Ray Boyd <http://leadingman.edublogs.org/2017/05/24/whats-wrong-with-a-guru-if-it-brings-about-improvement-to-classroom-practice-weve-talked-for-too-long/#comment-4>; and Darcy Moore http://www.darcymoore.net/2017/08/26/cult-hattie-wilful-blindness/?utm_campaign=crowdfire&utm_content=crowdfire&utm_medium=social&utm_source=twitter#3070802660-tw#1511311219926.
3. As an example, I get regular emails from ACEL promoting the latest Hattie inspired 'Visible XXX' workshop. The official partnership was announced in 2015 http://www.acer.org.au/acer/ACELWEB/News/Corwin_and_ACEL_announce_new_partnership.aspx.

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